Bent

By Martin Sherman

CUTTING NOTES are in RED; STAGE DIRECTIONS from the PLAY are in BLUE.

[RUDY and MAX crouched on the ground] A prisoner transport train. A GUARD *walks through the circle of light. He carries a rifle. [RUDY and MAX watch as GUARD crosses – actors should coordinate eye moment to give the illusion there is a GUARD] Silence.*

RUDY: (Pg 40-41) Where do you think they're taking us? *[Silence. The other prisoners look away The* GUARD *walks through the circle of light. Silence.] [To the* PRISONER *next to him]* Did you have a trial? [*The* PRISONER *doesn't answer.]*

MAX: Rudy . . . I . . . . *[Silence].*

RUDY *and* MAX *look at each other. They are both terrified.* RUDY *starts to extend his hand, then withdraws it. A scream* is *heard-off, beyond the circle. [Characters respond physically to the sound]* RUDY *and* MAX *look at each other, then turn away. Silence.*

Max assumes the role of OFFICER and *walks through the circle of light. Silence. Another scream. [Rudy responds physically to the sound] Silence. The OFFICER looks at the prisoners one by one. He stops at RUDY.]*

OFFICER: Glasses. *[Silence.]* Give me your glasses. [RUDY *hands the* OFFICER *his glasses. The* OFFICER *examines them.]* Horn-rimmed. Intelligensia.

RUDY: What?

OFFICER: *[Smiles.]* Stand up. *[Pulls* RUDY *up.]* Step on your glasses. [RUDY *stands-petrified.]* Step on them. [RUDY *steps on the glasses.]* Take him.

RUDY: Max! [RUDY *looks at* MAX. *The* OFFICER *pushes* RUDY *off-out of the circle. The* OFFICER *smiles.]*

OFFICER: Glasses. *[He kicks the glasses away]. Exits . . . MAX resumes his original role*

MAX *stares ahead. A scream* is *heard-off, beyond the circle.* RUDY'S *scream.* MAX *stiffens. Silence.* RUDY *screams again.*

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INTRODUCTION

In Bent, Martin Sherman tells a Holocaust story that no one had ever told before – The story of the persecution of homosexuals -- the lowest of the low in the concentration camp pecking order. The wearers of the Pink Triangle. Written in 1979, the struggle of Max to accept himself, to learn to love in the most unlikely of places, still carries meaning today.

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RUDY *screams again as stage is set for next scene [Scream during transition to Character of Horst]* MAX *moves, as if to get up.*

[The man wearing the pink triangle (HORST) *moves toward* MAX. *He touches him.]*

HORST: (Pg 42-43) Don't. *[He removes his hand from MAX and looks straight ahead. The GUARD walks through the circle of light.]* Don't move. You can't help him. *Silence. The GUARD walks through the circle of light.]*

MAX: This isn't happening. Where are they taking us?

HORST: It's happening. Dachau. I've been through transport before. They took me to Cologne for a propaganda film. Pink triangle in good health. Now it's back to Dachau.

MAX: Pink triangle? What's that?

HORST: Queer. If you're queer, that's what you wear. If you're a Jew, a yellow star. Political-a red triangle. Criminal-green. Pink's the lowest. *[He looks straight ahead].*

MAX: This isn't happening. *[Silence.]* This can't be happening. *[Silence.]*

HORST: Listen to me. If you survive the train, you stand a chance. Here's where they break you. You can do nothing for your friend. Nothing. If you try to help him, they will kill you. If you try to care for his wounds, they will kill you. If you even see -- see what they do to him, hear -- hear what they do to him -- they will kill you. If you want to stay alive, he cannot exist.

*******SCENE: At the prisoner camp, Dachau*******

[A tight little corner at the end of the barracks. HORST crawls in and sits huddled with his bowl. He drinks the soup. MAX enters, crawling in next to HORST. He carries a bowl. He wears the prison uniform. On it is a yellow star.]

MAX: (Pg 50-57) Hi. *[HORST looks at him; says nothing; MAX holds up his bowl.]* Here.

HORST: Leave me alone.

MAX: I got extra. Some vegetables. Here. *[Drops vegetables from his bowl into HORSTS]*

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HORST: Thanks. *[They eat in silence. HORST stares at MAX'S uniform.]* Yellow star? Jew?

MAX: Oh. Yeah.

HORST: I wouldn't have figured it. *[Silence.]* I'm sorry about your friend.

MAX: Who?

HORST: Your friend.

MAX: Oh. *[Silence.] [Points to HORST'S pink triangle.]* How'd you get the pink?

HORST: I signed a petition. . . for Magnus Hirschfeld.

MAX: Oh yeah. I remember him. Berlin. He wanted to. . .

HORST: Make queers legal. Looked like he would, too, for a while. It was quite a movement. Then the Nazis came in. Well. I was a nurse. They said a queer couldn't be a nurse. Suppose I had to touch a patient's penis! God forbid. They said rather than be a nurse, I should be a prisoner. A more suitable occupation. That's how I got my pink triangle. How'd you get the yellow star?

MAX: I'm Jewish.

HORST: You're not Jewish, you're a queer. *[Silence.]*

MAX: I didn't want one. You told me it was the lowest. So I didn't want one. I worked a deal.

HORST: A deal? With the Gestapo? You're full of shit. *[Silence.]*

MAX: I'm going to work a lot of deals. They can't keep us here forever. Sooner or later they'll release us. I'm only under protective custody, that's what they told me. I'm going to stay alive.

HORST: I don't doubt it. Thanks for the vegetables. *[Starts to crawl away.]*

MAX: Where are you going?

HORST: To sleep. We get up at four in the morning. I'm on stone detail.

MAX: Don't go. . . I'm not Jewish.

HORST: Then why are you wearing that?

MAX: You told me pink was the lowest.

HORST: It is, but only because the other prisoners hate us so much.

MAX: I got meat in my soup. You didn't. . . . You didn't think I'd make it, did you? Off the train?

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HORST: I wasn't sure.

MAX: I'm going to stay alive. Because of you. You told me how.

HORST: Yes. *[Pause.]* I did. *[Pause.]* You should be wearing a pink triangle.

MAX: I made a deal. They said if I . . . I could prove . . .

HORST: What? *[Silence.]*

MAX: They took me. . . into that room. . . on the train. And they said. . . prove that you're not. . .

HORST: Prove that you're not what?

MAX: Queer.

HORST: How?

MAX: They said, if you. . . Made love.

HORST: Who was she?

MAX: Maybe . . . maybe only thirteen . . . she was dead. Just. Just dead, minutes *[MAX indicates a gun at the temple]* They said prove that you're. . . and I did. . . lots of them, watching. . . laughing. . . He's a bit bent, they said, he can't . . . but I did . . . I wanted . . .

HORST: To stay alive.

MAX: She was like an angel . . . to save my life . . . *[Silence.]* And I said, I'm not queer. And they laughed. And I said, give me a yellow star. And they said, sure, make him a Jew. He's not bent. And they laughed. But. . . I. . . got. . . my. . . star.

HORST: Yes. *[Reaches out, touches MAX'S face.]*

MAX: Don't do that! *[Pulls away.]* You mustn't do that. For your own sake. You mustn't touch me. I'm a rotten person.

*******Scene: Max uses his "deals" to get Horst moved to rock detail*******

MAX: **(Pg 63-65)** You see those. . . You take one rock at a time. And move it over there. And then when the entire pile is over there, you take one rock at a time, and move it back.

HORST: *[Looks at MAX. Silence.]* And move it back? We move the rocks from there to there, and then back from there to there? Why?

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MAX: Start moving. He's watching. *[MAX continues to move rocks. HORST does the same. They do so in different rhythms, at times passing each other.]* It's supposed to drive us crazy. It makes no sense. It serves no purpose. I figured it out. They do it to drive us crazy.

HORST: They probably know what they're doing.

MAX: But it doesn't work. I figured it out. It's the best job to have. That's why I got you here.

HORST: What? *[Puts down his rock.]*

MAX: Don't stop. Keep moving. *[HORST picks up the rock and moves it.]* A couple more things. That fence. It's electric. Don't touch it. You fry. And over there-that pit.

HORST: Oh yes. It smells awful.

MAX: Bodies. Sometimes we have to throw them in.

HORST: Oh. Well, it will break the routine. **(Pg 68-71)** Where do the bodies come from?

MAX: The fence. The hat trick. Sometimes a guard throws a prisoner's hat against the fence. He orders him to get the hat. If he doesn't get the hat, the guard will shoot him. If he does get the hat, he'll be electrocuted.

HORST: I'm really going to like it here. Thanks a lot.

MAX: I'm really doing you a favor.

HORST: Some favor! You just want someone to talk to so you won't go crazy. And I'm the only one who knows your secret.

MAX: What secret?

HORST: That you're a pink triangle.

MAX: No. I'm a Jew now.

HORST: You are not. It's a lie.

MAX: It's a smart lie. I thought you'd be grateful.

HORST: I'm not grateful. I liked cutting stones. This is insane. Twelve hours of this a day? I'll be nuts in a week.

MAX: You haven't figured out this camp, that's all. You don't know what's good for you. This is the best job to have.

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HORST: Moving rocks back and forth for no reason. Next to a pit with dead bodies and a fence that can burn you to dust. The best job to have? *[They both move their rocks. A long silence.]*

MAX: I thought you'd be grateful.

*******Scene: Same work detail . . . months later*******

HORST: **(Pg 86)** I'm going crazy. *[Silence.]* I'm going crazy. *[Silence.]* I'm going crazy. I dream about rocks. I close my eyes and I'm moving rocks. Rocks never end. Never end. *[Silence.]* I'm going crazy.

MAX: Think of something else.

HORST: I can't think. I've been up all night. Didn't you hear? Our barracks had to stand outside all night. We stood at attention all night long . . . Punishment.

MAX: What for?

HORST: Someone in our barracks killed himself.

MAX: A moslem?

HORST: **(Pg 74)** No. That's what they call a dead person who walks. You know, one of those guys who won't eat anymore, won't talk anymore, just wanders around waiting to really die. **(Pg 86-93)** It doesn't mean anything if a moslem kills himself, but if a person who's still a person commits suicide, well . . . it's a kind of defiance, isn't it? They hate that -- it's an act of free will.

MAX: I'm sorry.

HORST: Sure. Yellow star is sorry. *[Silence.]* I'm going crazy.

MAX: O.K. O.K. You're going crazy. I'm sorry. It's my fault.

HORST: What do you mean your fault?

MAX: For bringing you here. Because you make me feel so guilty. And you should. This job is the worst. I figured it wrong. I'm sorry.

HORST: You should be with us, where you belong.

MAX: No. But you shouldn't be here.

HORST: I want to be here.

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MAX: Why?

HORST: Because. Because I love rocks. *[Pause.]* Because I love you. *[Silence.]* I do. I love you. When I'm not dreaming about rocks, I'm dreaming about you. For the past six weeks, I've dreamed about you. It helps me get up. It helps me make sure my bed is perfectly made so I'm not punished. It helps me eat the stinking food. It helps me put up with the constant fights in the barracks. Knowing I'll see you. At least out of the corner of my eyes. In passing. It's a reason to live. So I'm glad I'm here. *[MAX is at one pile of rocks, moving them into symmetrical piles.]*

HORST: What are you doing?

MAX: Arranging these neatly. We've gotten sloppy. They can beat you for it. *[Silence.]* Don't love me.

HORST: It's my secret. And I have a signal. No one knows it. When I rub my left eyebrow at you, like this ... *[Rubs his left eyebrow.]* ... it means I love you. Bet you didn't know that. I can even do it in front of the guards. No one knows. It's my secret. *[Starts to cough.]* It's cold.

MAX: Don't love me. I don't want anybody to love me. I can't love anybody back.

HORST: Who's asking you to?

MAX: Queers aren't meant to love. I know. They don't want us to. You know who loved me? [That boy . . . on the train.] I don't remember his name. But I killed him. See -- queers aren't meant to love. I'll kill you too. Hate me. That's better. Hate me. Don't love me. *[MAX finishes arranging the rocks. He returns to moving the rocks. Silence. HORST starts to cough again. Slips. Drops the rock and falls to the ground.]*

MAX: Horst! *[Puts down his rock.]*

HORST: Shit. *[MAX starts toward him.]* Don't move! He's watching. The guard. If you help me, they'll kill you. Get back to your rock. Do you hear me, get back! *[MAX returns, picks up his rock, but stands looking at HORST; HORST is coughing]* Move! *[MAX moves the rock.]* Don't ever help me. *[Pulls himself up.]* I'm up. It's O.K. *[Picks up his rock.]*Never notice. Never watch. I love you. But I won't help you if ***you*** fall. Don't you dare help me. We save ***ourselves***. Do you understand? Do you?

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MAX: Yes. I understand.

HORST: Promise me. Come on. Promise me. We save ourselves.

MAX: **(Pg 96-97)** You're losing weight. You need medicine.

HORST: It doesn't matter.

MAX: You're turning into a moslem. I'm scared.

*******Scene: Same work yard *******

[MAX assumes the role of CAPTAIN as HORST resumes moving rocks.] The CAPTAIN watches HORST. He paces up and down. HORST moves the rocks. The CAPTAIN paces. HORST coughs. He catches himself and tries to stifle it.]

CAPTAIN: **(Pg 112-117)** Ah. *[HORST stops the cough.]* You. Pervert.

HORST: *[Stiffens, stands still.]* Yes sir?

CAPTAIN: Are you ill?

HORST: No sir.

CAPTAIN: You have a cough. I heard you cough. You're not well.

HORST: I am, sir.

CAPTAIN: Put down that rock.

HORST: Yes sir. *[Puts down the rock.]*

CAPTAIN: Good. Now take off your hat.*[A long pause.]*

HORST: My hat, sir?

CAPTAIN: Yes. Your hat. *[HORST removes his hat]*

CAPTAIN: Throw your hat away. *[HORST flings his hat on the ground.]* Not there. Pick it up.

HORST: Yes sir. *[Picks up his hat.]*

CAPTAIN: Throw it on the fence. The fence. *[HORST starts to cough.]* That's all right. We'll wait. *[The cough subsides.]* Are you better?

HORST: Yes sir.

CAPTAIN: Nasty cough. On the fence. Now.

HORST: On the fence. Yes sir. *[HORST throws his hat on the fence. The fence sparks.]*

CAPTAIN: Get your hat. *[The CAPTAIN points his rifle at HORST.]*

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HORST: *[Is silent for a moment. Turns to the CAPTAIN]* Yes sir.

[HORST turns left, takes his hand and rubs his left eyebrow. He turns and stares at the CAPTAIN. The CAPTAIN waits. HORST turns toward the fence. He starts to walk very slowly to his hat. He almost reaches the fence, when, suddenly- He turns and rushes at the CAPTAIN. He screams in fury. The CAPTAIN shoots HORST. He falls, dead. Silence.]

*******SCENE: Max and Horst's dead body*******

MAX stares at HORST. Silence. MAX opens his mouth to cry out. He can't. Silence. MAX walks to HORST'S body.

MAX: **(Pg 119-120)** Nol *[He looks up-off-at the GUARD, then back at HORST. Silence.]* You don't have to worry about the rocks. I'll do yours, too. I'll move twice as many each day. I'll do yours, too. You don't have to worry about them. *[Silence.]* You know what? *[Silence.]* Horst? *[Silence.]* You know what? *[Silence.]* I think I love you. *[Silence.]* Shh! Don't tell anyone. I love you. *[Silence.]* What's wrong with that? *[He starts to cry.]*

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AWARD HISTORY

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